

PELICAN BAY POLICE DEPARTMENT
HOMICIDE DIVISION — EIGHTH DISTRICT
715 South Broad Avenue, New Orleans, LA 70119
(504) 658-6080

DETECTIVE'S CASE SUMMARY & SUPPLEMENTAL REPORT

Case No.: PBPD-2026-034532 | Document No.: 18

Reporting Detective: Det. Yvette Landry, Badge #1887

Date of Report: October 15, 2025

Status: Cleared by Arrest — Referred to Orleans Parish District Attorney

ADA Assigned: Roland Schexnayder, Asst. District Attorney

Case Classification: Homicide — Blunt Force Trauma

Victim: DAMARI KHALIL THORNTON, 34

Defendants: CODY A. CORMIER (28); BRETT M. PELLEGRINO (29); RYAN P. ROBICHEAUX (31)

I. CASE NARRATIVE

On the morning of October 4, 2025, Damari K. Thornton, a 34-year-old freelance investigative journalist visiting New Orleans from Atlanta, was beaten to death with a wooden baseball bat in the service alley behind The Rusty Anchor at 712 Bourbon Street. Thornton had spent the prior four months investigating a pattern of unsolved tourist assaults in the French Quarter and had identified three regulars at The Rusty Anchor — Trent Cormier, Marco Pellegrino, and Kyle Robicheaux — as the suspected core of the responsible group. On the night of his death, Thornton was conducting covert observation and audio recording inside the bar. He was identified by Cormier as a potential journalist or law-enforcement source. After Thornton exited the bar via the rear staff door at 2:25 AM, Cormier, armed with a souvenir wooden bat he routinely carried, exited with Pellegrino and Robicheaux approximately 85 seconds later. In the alley, Cormier confronted Thornton. Thornton attempted to retreat. Cormier delivered at least three to four blows to Thornton's head with the bat. Pellegrino shoved Thornton to the ground during the assault and was clawed by Thornton in self-defense (basis for the DNA recovery under Thornton's right-hand fingernails). Robicheaux did not strike Thornton and audibly attempted to stop Cormier. The three fled north through the alley, took a Lyft from Bourbon at St. Ann to Cormier's residence, and conspired to dispose of the bat (later recovered) and to remain silent. Thornton died at the scene; his body was discovered by an anonymous 911 caller (Camila Reyes) at approximately 2:38 AM.

II. EVIDENTIARY SUMMARY

Physical evidence implicating each defendant:

- **Cormier:** Cigarette butt (E-12) with single-source saliva DNA matching at 1 in 312 trillion (Doc 10); fingerprint on bat (Doc 11); shoe impression at scene strongly associated with his Vans (Doc 11); button at scene matched to his shirt (Doc 11); voice identified on victim's covert recording shortly before assault (Doc 12); admissions corroborating possession/use of the bat from co-defendants (Docs 15, 16).
- **Pellegrino:** DNA under victim's right-hand fingernails included at 1 in 4.3 billion (Doc 10); own admission to physical contact (shove) with victim and proximity to the assault (Doc 15); identified on camera in red shirt matching witness descriptions (Doc 9); corroboration by Robicheaux (Doc 16).
- **Robicheaux:** Hair on victim with included mtDNA haplotype (Doc 10); fiber consistent with his hoodie on victim (Doc 11); own statement under proffer placing him at scene as non-striking participant who attempted to stop Cormier (Doc 16).

Independent corroboration: Witness Pierce (Doc 6) — alley account, clothing, "Trent" name; Witness Acosta (Doc 8) — bar setup, Cormier's possession of the bat, departure timing; Camera (Doc 9) — visual and audio timing; Reyes (Doc 14) — three fleeing white males with bat; Lyft GPS log and driver statement (Doc 14).

III. CHARGING RECOMMENDATIONS

Trent Cormier: Second-Degree Murder (LRS 14:30.1); Obstruction of Justice (LRS 14:130.1); Conspiracy (LRS 14:26).

Marco Pellegrino: Second-Degree Murder (LRS 14:30.1, principal liability); Conspiracy (LRS 14:26).

Kyle Robicheaux: Manslaughter (LRS 14:31) or, with cooperation, Accessory After the Fact (LRS 14:25); Conspiracy (LRS 14:26). Final charging to reflect cooperation level under ADA Schexnayder's direction.

Additional charges under continuing investigation include possible separate counts arising from the August 2025 tourist assault and any additional incidents to which evidence may link these defendants. PBPD Homicide and Robbery/Assault Units will continue parallel work.

IV. OPEN INVESTIGATIVE ITEMS

1. Independent forensic voice comparison of Cormier's speech on Thornton's covert recording (request submitted to LSU Forensic Audio Lab, 10/14).
2. Tracing of Thornton's other 16 recovered audio files for additional admissions; coordination with PBPD Robbery/Assault Unit lead Sgt. Daria Pelletier.
3. Identification of "Anthony" referenced on Thornton's October 4 recording (possible bar-skim payment scheme).
4. Continued cooperation status review for defendant Robicheaux through ADA's office.
5. Coordination with Southern Ledger Online re: notes and source material; preserve subpoena duces tecum issued 10/13/2025.

V. CASE STATUS

Cleared by Arrest. Case referred to the Orleans Parish District Attorney's Office for prosecution on October 14, 2025. Status hearing scheduled October 22, 2025, Section L, Hon. Toussaint presiding. PBPD Homicide retains the investigative file as open for continued work on related incidents.

Reporting Detective: _____ Det. R. Landry #1887

Supervisor Approval: _____ Lt. Andre Fontenot, Homicide Unit

ADA Receipt: _____ J. Schexnayder, ADA — 10/15/2025

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